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RAGHU RAI, WHO is in his early 30s, loves his job. The delivery executive has graduated to a scooter from a bicycle within two months of joining Zepto, a quick commerce start-up. “It’s a satisfying job where I get to meet different kinds of people. It’s thrilling, too, as I race against time to deliver groceries,” says Rai. Then there is Guddu Kumar, 24, a Swiggy Instamart delivery person who moonlights at Zepto. His day starts at 7 am when he dons the orange Instamart jersey and cycles through Byculla, Mahalaxmi, Lower Parel

and Prabhadevi areas of Mumbai, delivering groceries. Come afternoon and Kumar undergoes a sartorial change—slipping into Zepto’s purple T-shirt. “Both jobs require me to work about seven hours and that seems doable since both have a solid tech infrastructure. But what stands out is that neither company penalises me over a delay in any order,” he says, smiling.

Rai and Kumar are obviously happy with work and life, but are customers happy with their employers—quick commerce players that promise to deliver anything from fresh strawberries to washing powder at their doorstep in a matter of minutes? To find out, *Business Today* placed three identical orders of potato chips and fresh strawberries on Instamart, Zepto and Blinkit. All three players have their warehouses, known rather spine-tinglingly as ‘dark stores’, within 1.5 km from the BT office in Mumbai’s Lower Parel.

The first to deliver was Zepto, in

a smart 6.35 minutes. It was also the cheapest at ₹150, as Zepto doesn’t charge for delivery. The next to arrive was Blinkit, which delivered our order in about 10 minutes with zero delivery charges as the order value was above ₹149. Else, it would have charged a delivery fee of about ₹20. The final delivery came from Instamart, in 14 minutes; plus, there was also a fast delivery fee of about ₹35.

Still, the timelines are impressive. How is it possible to deliver so quickly? The secret sauce is a network of dark stores across cities where these companies offer their services. A dark store is essentially a retail facility resembling a mini-warehouse that houses goods to fulfil online orders. The difference: it is not open to the public. In fact, it is usually out of bounds even for most employees, except those who actually work there.

For instance, Zepto, which has 200-250 dark stores in Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune, and Chennai, doesn’t allow

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Quick commerce players promise to deliver anything from fresh tomatoes to toothpaste at a customer’s doorstep in a matter of minutes

THE KNIGHT IN BLACK

Powering such rapid deliveries are networks of dark stores that stock the items needed to fulfil the orders



A dark store is generally a warehouse present in the heart of a city but it is not open to the public

Carved out of shuttered buildings or gone-out-of-business stores, these allow players to not only save costs, but also reach deep corners of cities and even semi-urban areas

Players such as Swiggy’s Instamart, Zomato’s Blinkit and Zepto are increasing their dark store count in a bid to expand reach, product portfolio and also to cut down on delivery times